

Blowin' with the teens

MTV's focus goes where the teen winds blow. The music channel is planning to capitalise on the teenage fascination with music and computers by launching two products—an MP3 player which can hold up to 11 hours of music and a PC packed with all the goodies that teenagers could possibly need. The MP3 player, which can also record and store music, is developed by MTV with DataPlay. It makes use of a new kind of disc drive developed by DataPlay—it can hold up to 500 MB of music.

MTV's teen PC is on a grander scale though. The Athlon-powered PC will have a flat-panel display, boast 'essential' tools such as CD-RW and DVD burners, and will come with a built-in radio, TV tuners, etc. MTV plans to position it in the \$1,800 segment, which is comparable to an AMD-powered high-end PC from Compaq. No teenybopper tune this.

Fabric keyboards

If SMS has given you sprained fingers, don't worry. A new fabric keyboard will help you out. This lightweight keyboard can be folded or stuffed into a pocket like a handkerchief, crumpled and, guess what, even washed like a fabric.

UK-based ElekSen is the company behind these fabric keyboards which are meant for use with mobile devices such as handhelds and cell

phones. A fabric keyboard designed specifically for PDAs is about to be launched in spring 2002. Plans are also afoot to release a lightweight mobile handset.

Bendable screens and keyboards are not a new concept, especially for mobile devices. Royal Philips Electronics is working on an 'electronic paper' for mobile phones and PDAs. This

rollable paper uses flexible energy-efficient polymer-based electronics.

Experts say these devices will be mass-produced in as soon as five years.



Philips refuses to play along

The recording industry wants you to stop sharing music so badly, that it hopes to physically prevent computer users from ripping audio CDs. A new breed of CDs has dawned, making them impossible to be read by PC-based CD drives.

This new controversial technology introduces small, physically minute errors in CDs. Though such errors can be corrected and compensat-

ed for in conventional CD players, unforgiving PC drives will have problems reading the media. Because of the sheer variety of installed CD players around the world, incompatibility issues are already cropping up.

Natalie Imbruglia's 'White Lilies Island' is already facing a number of returns on the grounds of CD players not being able to read it.

Philips, the co-creator of the CD is refusing to play along. The company has advised record labels to inform consumers that copy-protected CDs are in fact, not CDs at all and to issue suitable warnings. Since Philips owns the CD trademark, music labels would be barred from stamping the logo on each protected CD they make.

tomorrow's technology

The fourth force

How many people have had enough of GeForce3? Well, just in case you happen to be one of those ambitious folks, nVidia is announcing its latest graphics chip on February 5, 2002—the GeForce4.

The GPU (Graphics Processing Unit) code-named NV25 is closer to the processor than nVidia made for use in the Microsoft Xbox.

A desktop version of the chip, code-named NV17,

which was available only in the mobile version earlier, will also accompany the NV25. It sure is something to look forward to.

It is rumoured that the NV25 was originally scheduled to be out at the Consumer Electronics Show (CES) at Las Vegas in January, 2002. But nVidia apparently could not make it on schedule and pushed the date to February. Not surprising,



considering that nVidia aims at making the GF4 a lot more

powerful than the GF3. It is said to have six pixel lines as compared to GF3's four pipelines. Other goodies available in the NV25 are higher clock speeds, faster memory interfaces and improved antialiasing capabilities. So still in love your GeForce3? A pity that you have to upgrade it even before you could get to use it fully!